

THE LOW COUNTRIES

THE THREE COUNTRIES IN THIS REGION – Belgium, the Netherlands, and Luxembourg – are known as the Low Countries because much of their land is flat and low-lying. The Low Countries are also called “Benelux” after the customs union they formed in 1948. The Benelux union allows the free flow of goods between the three countries, although each keeps its own tax system. These are the most densely populated countries in Europe, yet their people generally enjoy a high standard of living. Although the region’s traditional heavy industries, such as coal mining, are declining, they are being replaced by modern manufacturing industries and service activities, such as banking and administration.

THINGS TO LOOK FOR ON THE MAP

Longest river: Meuse, France/Belgium/Netherlands, 560 miles (901 km) *Map J8*

Highest point: Botrange, Belgium, 2,277 ft (694 m) *Map J10*

Largest lake: IJsselmeer, Netherlands, 467 sq miles (1,210 sq km) *Map I5*



0 25 50 km
0 10 20 30 miles



Rotterdam is Europe's busiest and largest port.

RIVERS

Some of Europe's most important rivers flow through these countries, linking the interior with the coast. The most useful rivers for transportation and trade are the Rhine, Mosel, and Meuse. At the mouth of the Rhine River stands the port of Rotterdam. Stretching for 12 miles (20 km) along the river, the port can handle 300 cargo ships at a time. Canals are also important for linking the ports with the rivers and inland areas.



NETHERLANDS

Luxembourg, Luxembourg

Jan 33°F (1°C)
July 64°F (18°C)
Jan 2.4 in (61 mm)
July 2.4 in (61 mm)

De Bilt, Netherlands

Jan 36°F (2°C)
July 64°F (18°C)
Jan 2.7 in (68 mm)
July 3 in (77 mm)



BELGIUM



LUXEMBOURG

FARMLAND

The region's flat plains are used for grazing dairy cattle and for growing flowers and vegetables. Much of the farmland has been reclaimed from the sea by enclosing areas with earth barriers, called dykes, and draining out the water. The only areas of high land are the forested Ardennes Mountains, which run across the south of Belgium and into Luxembourg.

